Chapter Nine

The Heiji Disturbance

Between 1142 and 1159,
the emperors of Japan battle with the
Fujiwara clan for power,
and the Taira and Minamoto join the fight

IN 1142, a three-year-old boy was crowned emperor of Japan.

His name was Konoe, and no one expected him to actually *rule*; two retired emperors were already battling over that privilege. In fact, Japan was suffering from an embarrassment of emperors.

BY THE ELEVENTH CENTURY, members of the ambitious and powerful Fujiwara clan had dug themselves firmly into top positions in the Japanese government. Generation after generation, imperial princes had married Fujiwara brides. Fujiwara ministers of state, usually close male relations of the reigning empress, dominated weak or young rulers. Emperor after emperor was crowned and then retreated behind the scenes to pursue poetry and luxurious living, political ceremony and religious ritual.*

In 1068, the emperor Go-Sanjo—a younger half brother, unexpectedly crowned after the premature death of his older sibling—had broken the pattern.

Unlike the string of emperors who came before, Go-Sanjo did not have a